

IMPLEMENTATION OF QUALITY MANAGEMENT IN ISLAMIC RELIGIOUS EDUCATION LEARNING IN MULTICULTURAL CULTURE

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Abstract

This study aims to analyze the application of quality management in Islamic Religious Education (IRE) in fostering students' religious character and developing religious culture in the multicultural educational environment of SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke. A qualitative case study approach in a constructivist paradigm is used. Participants, including principals, IRE teachers, administrative staff, and students, were selected through purposive sampling. Data were collected through participant observation, semi-structured interviews, and document analysis, and analyzed using Miles and Huberman's interactive model with triangulation to ensure trust. The findings show that quality management has been systematically implemented through continuous planning, organization, implementation, supervision, and evaluation. These practices strengthen students' religious character by integrating Islamic values into learning, school culture, role models, and religious habits. The cultural development of religious schools is supported by effective leadership, competent teachers, stakeholder collaboration, and continuous quality improvement. Overall, integrating quality management with Islamic Religious Education and multicultural values has created an inclusive educational environment that enhances religious character, social harmony, and sustainable quality of education.

Keywords

Islamic Religious Education, Quality Management, Learning Management, Multicultural Education, Religious Culture.



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INTRODUCTION

Muhammadiyah educational institutions consistently encourage educational reform by integrating Islamic values, modern knowledge, and social responsibility (Nurzam & Maujud, 2025); (Irna Prayetno, 2025); (Ummamah et al., 2023). This educational orientation is particularly relevant in multicultural areas such as Merauke, South Papua, where diverse ethnic, cultural, and religious communities interact in daily life (Habiby, 2017); (Robertson et al., 2018). As one of the Islamic schools in this region, SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke strives to maintain the quality of education while fostering religious values and multicultural harmony through the implementation of quality management in Islamic Religious Education (PAI). Education quality management is a systemic approach that aims to ensure and improve quality in a sustainable manner through the cycle of planning, implementation, evaluation, and follow-up (Sallis, 2014); (Makbuloh, 2011). However, the implementation of quality management in schools with a multicultural background like Merauke faces its own challenges, because it not only demands high academic standards, but also the ability to manage diversity in the learning process.

The implementation of quality management in PAI learning at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke is implemented through the stages of planning, implementation, evaluation, and follow-up. The findings of the study show that at the planning stage, PAI teachers prepare learning tools by considering the standards and quality indicators set by the school. Based on the results of interviews with PAI teachers, learning planning is directed at achieving students' learning completeness by using a minimum score standard of 75, as well as encouraging the use of active and innovative learning methods. This information is strengthened through the documentation of PAI learning tools, especially lesson plans/teaching modules and assessment documents that show indicators of competency achievement and learning completeness criteria. The integration of multicultural values in learning is also found in the learning tools and confirmed through interviews with PAI teachers regarding learning strategies that are tailored to the diversity of students' backgrounds.

At the implementation stage, the results of observations on the PAI learning process showed that teachers used a variety of learning methods, including group discussions, socio-religious case studies, and collaborative activities between students. Based on the results of interviews with PAI teachers, the use of these methods is intended to increase student activity while building mutual respect in the midst of a diversity of cultural and social backgrounds. The findings of these

observations are strengthened through documentation of learning activities, in the form of learning tools, teaching materials, and documentation of discussion activities and group work. Thus, data on the implementation of quality management in PAI learning is not only sourced from informant statements but is obtained through triangulation of interviews, observations, and documentation. This pattern is in line with research on PAI learning quality management, which uses these three techniques to obtain an overview of learning planning, implementation, and evaluation.

This is in line with Puspitasari's findings that the PAI learning model, which is inclusive, dialogical, reflective, and culturally responsive, has proven to be effective in fostering tolerance, empathy, and appreciation for diversity (Puspitasari, 2026). Preliminary data from preliminary observations showed that PAI teachers at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke have used 4 out of 7 learning quality management indicators, namely: (1) the achievement of learning objectives according to the lesson plan, (2) the use of inclusive learning media, (3) the active involvement of students in discussions, and (4) the provision of feedback on learning outcomes. The evaluation stage is carried out through daily tests, mid-term assessments, and end-of-semester assessments with minimum completeness standards, as well as process evaluation through teacher observation and student satisfaction questionnaires. Meanwhile, the follow-up stage is manifested in a remedial, enrichment, and reflection program at the end of each semester involving teachers, principals, and school committees. Based on school document data, the average completeness of PAI learning in the 2024/2025 school year reached 78.6%, with the student satisfaction rate with PAI learning of 82% of the total 120 students who filled out the questionnaire. This achievement shows that the application of quality management principles, such as *Total Quality Management* (TQM), has a positive impact on improving organizational effectiveness, educator professionalism, and overall quality of learning outcomes (Arga et al., 2025).

The application of multicultural values in the implementation of Islamic Religious Education (PAI) learning at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke is carried out through the integration of the values of tolerance (*tasamuh*), respect for differences, justice, and brotherhood (*ukhuwah*) in the learning process. Based on the results of interviews with PAI teachers, these values are not only conveyed as theoretical material, but are also directed to shape students' attitudes in interacting with friends who have differences in ethnicity, culture, and religious backgrounds. The teacher explained that PAI material related to human relations, harmony, tolerance, and morals towards others is used as a space to instill an attitude of respect for differences. The findings of the interview were

strengthened through the results of observation of the learning process, which showed that teachers provided opportunities for students to discuss and express opinions while respecting the views of different friends. In addition, the documentation of PAI learning tools showed the existence of learning materials and objectives related to the formation of social attitudes, tolerance, and respect for diversity.

The application of multicultural values is also seen in the pedagogical approach used by teachers in the learning process. Based on the results of observations, teachers implemented discussion and group work activities involving students with diverse backgrounds. In these activities, students were directed to work together, listen to the opinions of group members, and respect differences of views. The results of interviews with PAI teachers showed that the selection of group activities is one of the strategies to build inclusive interaction and develop mutual respect among students. Thus, the application of multicultural values in PAI learning at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke was found through the relationship between learning content, pedagogical strategies, and student interaction practices in the classroom.

The adaptive multicultural-based PAI curriculum development model includes five core components: multicultural Islamic value orientation, inclusive curriculum goals, local wisdom-based integrative content, dialogical-participatory learning strategies, and character-based authentic evaluation (Multicultural, 2026). Pedagogically, teachers use cooperative learning methods such as *jigsaw* and *think-pair-share*, which facilitate students from various ethnic backgrounds (such as students of the Marind, Muyu, Javanese, Bugis, and Toraja tribes) to work together and learn from each other. Teachers also consciously use case examples that are relevant to Merauke's social reality, such as minor conflicts between groups, differences in religious traditions, or celebrations of holidays involving various communities. Contextual approaches and real examples from all madrasah members are key in the process of internalizing Islamic values such as tolerance, responsibility, discipline, and social concern (Madrasah Management in Improving the Quality of Learning and Character Development of Students, 2025). Culturally, schools create an inclusive learning climate with policies of using polite language of instruction, prohibition of hate speech, and the habit of cross-cultural greeting. Observation data conducted over three months showed that in 20 PAI learning meetings, teachers integrated multicultural values in 16 meetings (80%), with the most common forms of integration being the use of multicultural case examples (45%), discussions between ethnic groups (30%), and collaborative project assignments (25%). Students also reported

that they felt more understanding and appreciation for differences after participating in multiculturally integrated PAI learning, with an average score of 4.1 out of 5 on the indicator of respect for differences in the multicultural attitude questionnaire. This confirms that multicultural education in the context of Islamic education not only transmits religious knowledge, but also forms personalities with moral and moderate character (Madrasah Management in Improving the Quality of Learning and Character Development of Students, 2025) (Hamdani, 2017).

Febrina and Sesmiarni's research shows that the implementation of education quality management in Islamic schools is carried out through the systematic management of various educational components to improve the quality of education services (Febrina & Sesmiarni, 2024). The quality management of Islamic education through planning, organizing, implementing, and controlling is able to support the improvement of the quality of Islamic education programs (Badriyah et al., 2024). The application of the multicultural Islamic Religious Education (PAI) model in secondary schools can accommodate the diversity of students through learning that instills the value of tolerance and respect for differences (Hamdan et al., 2022). Multicultural values in religious education can be strengthened through the process of institutionalization in school policies, learning, and culture (Ma'rifah & Sibawaihi, 2023). The transformation of PAI learning in a multicultural context can be carried out through an inclusive approach that provides space for the diversity of identities and experiences of students (Afriyanto & Anandari, 2024).

A multicultural approach to PAI learning can strengthen interfaith tolerance through inclusive learning interactions (Widat & Ummah, 2025). The implementation of multicultural-based PAI contributes to the formation of students' character through the development of mutual respect and acceptance of diversity (Utomo, 2024). Multicultural-based PAI learning can be used to realize student tolerance through integrating diversity values in the learning process (Ramadani, 2024). The strategies of PAI teachers play an important role in improving the multicultural aspects of learning, especially through the development of learning materials, methods, and interactions that respect diversity (Achmada & Pratama, 2023). Meanwhile, multicultural project-based learning in PAI can be a strategy to develop inclusive attitudes while preventing intolerant behavior in the school environment. Overall, the ten studies show that quality management and multicultural-based PAI learning can support improving the quality of learning, tolerance, and character formation of students (Saputro et al., 2026).

Several related studies. First, the integration of multicultural values in the PAI quality management system contributes to the development of contextual curriculum, inclusive and dialogical learning, strengthening the professionalism of educators, and the formation of a democratic and moral culture in Islamic educational institutions. This research confirms that multicultural-based PAI quality management functions not only as an administrative instrument, but also as a pedagogical and ideological strategy in forming religious, tolerant, and socially responsible students. However, this research is theoretical (literature study) and has not examined its real implementation in the field, especially in multicultural areas such as Papua (Arifin et al., 2026).

Second, the Islamic value-based quality management development model achieved a feasibility score of 70.3% and an effectiveness rate of 78%, this model includes five main aspects: (1) focus on service quality, (2) involvement of all stakeholders, (3) continuous improvement process, (4) proactive scientific and policy approaches, and (5) harmonious leadership and teamwork. Pragmatically, this model has brought improvements in PAI quality management support facilities, empowerment of PAI teachers, integration of Islamic values with the multicultural values of the Alor community, and strengthening of the school's leadership commitment. This research is relevant because it was conducted in a Muhammadiyah environment with a multicultural context, but its location in East Nusa Tenggara has different cultural characteristics from South Papua (Abdullah et al., 2025).

Third, research on the strategy of PAI teachers in instilling multicultural values in SMP Negeri 2 Merauke, South Papua, shows that PAI teachers use strategic measures such as the preparation of appropriate lesson plans, learning models *Problem Based Learning* (PBL), and PAIKEM (Active, Innovative, Creative, Effective, and Fun Learning), as well as extracurricular activities (Multicultural, 2025). The multicultural values instilled include inclusive, humanist, tolerant, democratic, and fraternal values. The supporting factors include the school climate, infrastructure, the role of teachers, school programs and activities, and interactions between components in schools. This research is important because it was conducted in Merauke—the same location as this study—and proves that the implementation of PAI in multicultural areas faces challenges as well as opportunities. However, this study only focuses on teachers' strategies and has not studied systematically how quality management functions as a strategic umbrella that integrates the quality of PAI learning and multicultural values in an integrated manner.

Fourth, that multicultural-based quality management not only improves academic quality, but also strengthens inclusive and moderate religious attitudes (Jalil & Munif, 2022). Just like the first study, this study is theoretical and has not provided empirical evidence of implementation in certain educational institutions.

Fifth, the dimensions of Banks' multicultural education (integration of content, knowledge construction, prejudice reduction, equality pedagogy, and school cultural empowerment) can be theoretically adapted into the PAI curriculum in Indonesia. This study analyzes PAI curriculum documents, including KMA No. 347/2022 and Banks' works, through integrative hermeneutic techniques. Its main contribution is the layered epistemological compatibility framework between multicultural education and Islamic education. However, this research is still conceptual and has not tested the implementation of the framework in the field, especially in schools with high cultural diversity (Anne, 2015).

Based on the five previous studies, several research gaps can be identified. First, theoretically, quality management, Islamic education, and multicultural education are generally discussed as separate frameworks. There is no integrative model that comprehensively explains how the three can be synergized in one integrated education management system. Second, empirically, most research is conducted through literature studies or in a relatively homogeneous educational environment. Field research that examines real implementation in schools with high levels of cultural diversity is still very limited. Third, contextually, there has been no research that specifically examines the implementation of quality management in PAI learning in the South Papua region, which has the characteristics of ethnic pluralism (Marind, Muyu, Javanese, Bugis, Toraja, and others) and a religion that is distinctive and different from other regions in Indonesia.

The novelty of this research lies in several things. First, this study offers an integrative model that connects quality management (as a systemic approach), PAI (as a learning substance), and multicultural culture (as a social context) in one analytical framework. Second, this study provides empirical evidence from the field on how the implementation of quality management takes place at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke, which is located in an area with a high level of cultural and religious diversity, so that it is different from previous studies that were theoretical or conducted in a homogeneous environment. Third, this study examines specifically how quality management supports the effectiveness of PAI learning while strengthening multicultural values—an issue that has not been touched much in the literature, especially in the context of South Papua. Thus, this

research fills the academic gap by presenting a new perspective that combines education quality management, PAI learning, and multicultural education in a complete and contextual manner.

The purpose of this study is to analyze the implementation of quality management in Islamic Religious Education (PAI) learning at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke in the context of multicultural culture. In particular, this study aims to: (1) analyze the planning, implementation, supervision, and evaluation of quality management in PAI learning; (2) describe the application of multicultural values in the PAI learning process; (3) analyze the role of quality management in supporting the strengthening of religious character, tolerance, and social harmony of students; and (4) identify supporting factors and obstacles in the implementation of PAI learning quality management in school environments that have cultural and religious diversity.

METHOD

This study uses a qualitative case study design to investigate the application of quality management in Islamic Religious Education (IRE) in the multicultural education environment of SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke, South Papua, Indonesia. The location of the study was deliberately chosen because SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke represents an Islamic high school operating in a multicultural area where Islamic values are integrated with multicultural education. Participants were selected using purposive and snowball sampling techniques and included school principals, Islamic Religious Education teachers, administrative staff, and students who were actively involved in academic and religious activities. Sampling continued until data saturation was achieved. Data were collected through participant observation, semi-structured interviews, and document analysis. The research observation was carried out for three months in the even semester of the 2024/2025 school year, namely January to March 2025, at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke. Observations were made directly on the learning process of Islamic Religious Education (PAI) in the classroom, religious habituation activities, and social interaction of students from various cultural backgrounds. Observations were conducted periodically during the research period to obtain data on the implementation of PAI learning quality management and the application of multicultural values in the school environment. Observations focused on classroom learning, religious activities, school culture, and teacher-student interaction. Interviews explored participants' perceptions and experiences regarding quality management practices, while document analysis examined teaching modules, lesson plans, curriculum documents, school regulations, annual and semester programs,

and other institutional records. The researcher served as the primary research instrument and kept detailed field records during the research.

Data analysis is carried out interactively from the data collection process until the research is completed using the Miles and Huberman model, which includes data condensation, data presentation, and conclusion drawing and verification. At the data condensation stage, the researcher collects and selects data from the results of interviews with school principals, PAI teachers, administrative staff, and students, records of PAI learning observation results, and school documents. Interview data is transcribed, then parts related to the focus of the research are coded. The initial codes are grouped based on the focus of the research, namely (1) planning for the quality management of PAI learning, (2) the implementation of PAI learning, (3) evaluation and follow-up of learning, (4) the application of tolerance values (*tasamuh*), (5) respect for differences, (6) justice, (7) brotherhood (*ukhuwah*), and (8) supporting factors and obstacles to the implementation of quality management in a multicultural environment.

At the data presentation stage, the results of coding from interviews, observations, and documentation were arranged in a thematic matrix to see the relationship between informant statements, observed learning practices, and documentary evidence. For example, PAI teachers' information on the use of group discussions to foster mutual respect was compared to the results of observations on classroom discussion activities and learning tool documents containing these activities. Similarly, the principal's information on learning quality improvement policies was compared to school program documents and their implementation in the field. This method was used to determine whether the information obtained through the interviews was in accordance with the observed practices and available documents.

The next stage is the drawing and verification of conclusions. The researcher identifies the patterns that emerge from the thematic matrix, then relates the pattern to the research focus on the implementation of PAI learning quality management in a multicultural culture. Provisional conclusions obtained during the analysis process are re-examined with interview data, observation notes, and documents. If different information is found between the informant and the interview results, observations, and documentation, the researcher clarifies the informant and re-examines the relevant documents. The validity of the findings is carried out through source triangulation, technique triangulation, and time triangulation, namely comparing information from school principals, PAI teachers, administrative staff, and students; comparing the results of interviews,

observations, and documentation; and comparing the data obtained at different data collection times. With this procedure, the research conclusions are built based on a consistent pattern of field data regarding quality management practices and the application of multicultural values in PAI learning at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke.

FINDINGS AND DISCUSSION

Findings

This research was carried out at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke which is located in Merauke Regency, South Papua Province. This school was chosen as the research location because it has unique characteristics as an Islamic educational institution that operates in a multicultural society with diverse ethnic, cultural, and religious backgrounds. This research aims to describe the implementation of quality management in Islamic Religious Education (PAI) learning as well as the development of religious culture in a multicultural school environment.

Data collection was carried out through participatory observation, in-depth interviews with school principals, PAI teachers, students, and school committees, as well as documentation of various school documents such as Learning Implementation Plans (RPP), annual and semester programs, teaching modules, and records of religious activities. Observation was carried out for three months in the even semester of the 2024/2025 school year, by directly observing the PAI learning process in the classroom, religious habituation activities, and social interactions between students from various cultural backgrounds. Interviews were conducted with 12 informants, consisting of 1 school principal, 3 PAI teachers, 6 students from various ethnic backgrounds (Marind, Muyu, Javanese, Bugis, and Toraja), and 2 school committee representatives. Documentation was carried out on learning planning documents, evaluation notes, and school activity reports.

The collected data were then analyzed using data reduction techniques, data presentation, and drawing conclusions according to the Miles and Huberman analysis model. To ensure the validity of the data, this study used source triangulation and method triangulation. Source triangulation was carried out by comparing information from principals, teachers, students, and school committees, while method triangulation was carried out by comparing data from observations, interviews, and documentation. The results of the study were presented in the form of a descriptive table that summarized field findings regarding the implementation of quality management in PAI learning and the development of religious culture at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah

Merauke.

Table 1. Implementation of Quality Management in Islamic Religious Education Learning in Multicultural Culture at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke

No.	Quality Management Implementation	Empirical Evidence of Quality Management Implementation	Developing a Religious Culture	Empirical Evidence of Religious Culture Development
1.	Quality Management Planning	Teachers prepare teaching modules, annual and semester programs, learning objectives, and assessment plans based on the <i>Merdeka Curriculum</i> .	Learning Planning	PAI teachers systematically prepare teaching modules, annual and semester programs, lesson plans, assessment strategies, and instructional media in accordance with the <i>Merdeka Curriculum</i> .
2.	Organization of Learning Activities	Teaching responsibilities, classroom management, instructional media, and learning resources are systematically organized according to teachers' expertise and students' learning needs.	Implementation of Religious Culture	Religious values are internalized through daily practices, including congregational prayers, <i>Dhuha</i> prayer, Qur'an recitation, <i>Tahfiz</i> , <i>Yasin</i> recitation, <i>Istighasah</i> , Ramadan social programs, <i>Qurban</i> , and other religious activities integrated into school life.
3.	Learning Implementation	Islamic Religious Education is delivered through interactive, contextual, student-centered learning strategies supported by technology.	Teacher's Role	Teachers serve as role models by demonstrating discipline, courtesy, responsibility, tolerance, and respect for cultural diversity while implementing interactive and student-centered learning strategies.
4.	Quality Control and Evaluation	Continuous monitoring and evaluation are conducted to improve learning effectiveness and the overall quality of education.	School Leadership	School leaders strengthen quality management through selective teacher recruitment, emphasizing professional competence, religious commitment, and active participation in Islamic educational activities.
5.	Teacher Professional Development	Teachers regularly participate in professional training and curriculum development programs to enhance their instructional competencies.	Multicultural Education	Multicultural values are integrated into Islamic Religious Education by promoting tolerance, equality, mutual respect, and appreciation of ethnic, cultural, and religious diversity.

6.	Integration of Multicultural Values	Learning activities promote tolerance, respect for diversity, equality, and harmonious relationships among students from different cultural backgrounds.	Student Character Development	Students demonstrate increased religious commitment, discipline, honesty, responsibility, social awareness, respectful behavior, and tolerance toward diverse cultural backgrounds.
7.	Stakeholder Participation	School leaders, teachers, parents, students, and the community collaborate to support the implementation of educational quality management.	Supporting Factors	Implementation is supported by effective school leadership, competent teachers, stakeholder collaboration, a relevant curriculum, adequate learning facilities, parental involvement, and technology integration.
8.	Learning Support	The use of digital learning media, extracurricular activities, and contextual instructional materials enhances student engagement and learning outcomes.	Inhibiting Factors	Challenges include limited worship facilities, insufficient funding, varying levels of student motivation, and distractions resulting from excessive smartphone use and online gaming.
9.	Challenges	Implementation is constrained by limitations in educational facilities and infrastructure, as well as the need for continuous adaptation to technological developments.	Improvement Strategies	Continuous quality improvement is achieved through teacher supervision, student motivation, innovative teaching methods, stakeholder collaboration, and ongoing evaluation of educational programs.
10.	Key Empirical Findings	Quality management in Islamic Religious Education has successfully strengthened learning quality, religious character, and multicultural awareness through continuous improvement and collaborative school governance.	Key Empirical Findings	Quality management in Islamic Religious Education successfully integrates religious and multicultural values, creating an inclusive school culture that strengthens students' religious character, social harmony, and educational quality.

Source: Compiled by Researcher based on Field Data (2026)

Table 1 presents empirical findings regarding the implementation of quality management in Islamic Religious Education learning and religious culture development at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke. This table consists of four main columns, namely the sequence number column, the quality management implementation column and its empirical evidence, and the religious culture development column and its empirical evidence. Overall, this table summarizes

ten aspects of field findings obtained through observation, interviews, and documentation.

In the aspect of quality management planning, the findings show that PAI teachers prepare teaching modules, annual and semester programs, learning objectives, and assessment plans that refer to the Independent Curriculum. The same applies to the aspect of learning planning in the development of religious culture, where PAI teachers systematically prepare learning tools that are integrated with religious values. In the aspect of organization, the findings show that the responsibility of teaching, classroom management, instructional media, and learning resources are systematically regulated according to the teacher's expertise and the learning needs of students, while in the aspect of the application of religious culture, religious values are internalized through various daily worship practices such as congregational prayers, Dhuha prayers, Tahfiz Al-Qur'an, Yasinan, Istighasah, as well as social activities such as social service, zakat, qurban, and commemoration of Islamic holidays.

In the aspect of learning implementation, PAI is delivered through learning strategies that are interactive, contextual, student-centered, and supported by technology. Teachers also act as role models by demonstrating discipline, politeness, responsibility, tolerance, and respect for cultural diversity. In the aspect of control and evaluation, schools conduct continuous supervision and evaluation to improve learning effectiveness, while school leadership strengthens quality management through selective teacher recruitment by emphasizing professional competence and religious commitment. In the aspect of teacher professional development, teachers regularly participate in professional training and curriculum development programs, while in the aspect of multicultural education, multicultural values are integrated into PAI learning by promoting tolerance, equality, mutual respect, and respect for ethnic, cultural, and religious diversity.

In the aspect of integrating multicultural values, learning activities promote tolerance, respect for diversity, equality, and harmonious relationships between students from various cultural backgrounds, which in turn has an impact on the development of students' character, which is characterized by increased religious commitment, discipline, honesty, responsibility, social awareness, and tolerance. In the aspect of stakeholder participation, school principals, teachers, parents, students, and the community collaborate in supporting the implementation of education quality management, which is the main supporting factor for this implementation. In the aspect of learning support, the use of digital media and extracurricular activities increases student involvement, while the inhibiting factors found include limited worship facilities, insufficient funds,

varied student motivation, and disruption in the use of gadgets and online games.

In terms of challenges, the implementation of quality management faces obstacles in the form of limited educational facilities and infrastructure, and the need to adapt to technological developments, which are overcome through continuous improvement strategies such as teacher supervision, student motivation, innovative teaching methods, stakeholder collaboration, and sustainable program evaluation. Overall, the main empirical findings show that quality management in Islamic Religious Education at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke has succeeded in strengthening the quality of learning, religious character, and multicultural awareness of students through a culture of continuous improvement and collaborative school governance. This implementation ultimately creates an inclusive school culture that strengthens religious character, social harmony, and overall quality of student education.

Discussion

Implementation of Quality Management of Islamic Religious Education in Multicultural Culture

The results of the study show that the implementation of Islamic Religious Education (PAI) quality management at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke is carried out through continuous planning, organization, implementation, monitoring, and evaluation. Each management function is directed not only at the achievement of academic competence, but also at the formation of religious character and students' ability to live in a diverse environment. Teachers develop learning tools, choose strategies that suit the characteristics of students, use learning media, and carry out periodic evaluations. These findings show that the quality of PAI learning is understood as a process that includes aspects of academics, character, and social life of students.

The findings are in line with the concept of *Total Quality Management* (TQM) in education, which places continuous improvement and the involvement of all elements of the organization as an important part of quality improvement (Sallis, 2014); (Aziz & Mahmood, 2018)(Mahmood et al., 2024); (Texeira-Quiros et al., 2022). In the context of SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke, this principle can be seen through the involvement of school principals, teachers, education staff, and students in the learning process and development of school culture. Thus, quality management not only functions as an administrative mechanism but also as an approach to building a school culture that supports the formation of religious character and tolerance.

From the perspective of multicultural education, PAI learning at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke shows an effort to integrate religious values with respect for diversity. The values of

tolerance, mutual respect, cooperation, justice, and brotherhood are developed through learning and social interaction in schools. This practice reinforces the view that schools are a social space to build appreciation for students' differences in culture, religion, and social backgrounds (Gollnick & Chinn, 2024). Religious education in this context is not placed as a means of group exclusivity, but as a moral foundation for building harmonious social relationships.

The findings are also in line with Zakiah Daradjat's view of PAI as a process of personality formation that is reflected in daily attitudes and behaviors (Dedi & Defiriono, 2024); (Tsoraya et al., 2022). At SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke, religious values are not only conveyed through learning materials, but are also strengthened through habituation, teacher examples, religious activities, and social interaction. Thus, the success of PAI learning can be seen from the ability of students to actualize religious values in behavior, such as discipline, responsibility, politeness, care, and respect for others.

The results of the study also show that the management function is closely related to the sustainability of PAI learning. Planning provides direction to learning objectives, the organization regulates available resources, implements translating plans into learning activities, while monitoring and evaluation are used to determine the achievement of goals and determine next improvements. This pattern is in line with research on education quality management which emphasizes the importance of implementing management functions consistently to improve the quality of learning (Aripin & Nurdiansyah, 2022); (Taja et al., 2021). This means that improving the quality of PAI cannot be separated from the school management system that is carried out in a planned and sustainable manner.

In the multicultural context of Merauke, the implementation of quality management has more complex characteristics because learning takes place in an environment with ethnic and cultural diversity. Therefore, the quality of learning is not measured through academic achievement, but also through the school's ability to create an inclusive learning environment. These findings strengthen the study of multicultural Islamic education that places appreciation for diversity as part of the educational process (Noe et al., 2026). Differences in students' backgrounds can be a source of social learning if managed through open, dialogical, and respectful interactions.

Development of Religious Culture at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke

The development of religious culture at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke takes place through the integration of Islamic values in academic and non-academic activities. Religious

practices, teacher examples, habituation activities, PAI learning, and social interaction are part of the process of forming school culture. Religious culture is not formed only through ceremonial religious activities, but through practices that are carried out consistently so that religious values develop into the habits of students.

These findings strengthen the view that the formation of religious character requires the involvement of various elements of the school. School principals play a role in providing policy direction, teachers become role models as well as facilitators of learning, while students become the main actors in the practice of school culture. The involvement of parents and the community is also a supporting factor for the sustainability of habituation. This pattern shows that religious culture is the result of interaction between leadership, learning, example, habituation, and the social environment.

The religious culture that develops in schools is also related to the formation of students' attitudes towards diversity. The value of tolerance and respect for differences is not positioned as something that is contrary to Islamic identity, but as a form of actualization of religious values in social life. These findings are in line with the perspective of multicultural education that places schools as a space to develop the ability to live together in diversity (Akcaoglu, 2021); (Gollnick & Chinn, 2024). In the context of SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke, PAI learning has a strategic opportunity to bring together religious values with the social reality of students.

Previous research has also shown that the internalization of multicultural values is more effective when it is not only incorporated into the curriculum, but is embodied in academic culture and school life (Noe et al., 2026); (Maharani & Kurniawan, 2023); (Kholida et al., 2025). The findings of this study show a similar pattern. Religious practices, teacher examples, cooperation, and interaction between students become spaces to develop tolerance and respect for diversity. Thus, quality management functions as a framework that keeps the process going systematically and sustainably.

However, the development of religious culture still faces several obstacles, especially the limitation of religious facilities, funding support, the motivation of some students, and the influence of less controlled use of digital media. These conditions show that the development of religious culture does not only depend on PAI teachers, but requires institutional support and involvement of the entire school community. Improving quality, therefore, needs to be directed at the provision of facilities, strengthening teacher competence, supervising activities, and evaluating programs on

a regular basis.

Overall, this study shows that the integration of quality management, PAI, and multicultural education can form a school ecosystem that is not only oriented towards academic achievement, but also towards religious character, tolerance, and the ability to live together in diversity. Quality management provides a systematic management framework, PAI provides a foundation for values, while multicultural culture becomes the social context in which these values are practiced. These findings reinforce previous research that placed the functions of management, Islamic education, and school culture as interrelated elements in quality improvement and character formation (Aripin & Nurdiansyah, 2022); (Taja et al., 2021); (Olan et al., 2019).

CONCLUSION

This research shows that quality management in Islamic Religious Education (PAI) learning at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke is carried out systematically through planning, organizing, implementing, monitoring, and evaluating. Its implementation can be seen in learning planning, the use of student-centered strategies, evaluation of learning outcomes, and follow-up to improve the quality of learning. The application of quality management also supports the integration of multicultural values through learning and school culture that instills tolerance, respect for differences, responsibility, cooperation, and brotherhood.

The success of the implementation is supported by school leadership, teacher competence, community involvement, and commitment to continuous improvement. However, the implementation still faces limitations in facilities and funding, variations in student motivation, and the influence of digital media use. Thus, quality management in PAI learning at SMA Plus Muhammadiyah Merauke not only plays a role in improving the quality of learning but also serves as a management framework to strengthen religious character and build a tolerant attitude in a multicultural school environment.

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